made clear to Cross that ‘you are authorised in the last resort to order on your own responsibility nuclear retaliation by all means at your disposal’.[21]

The delegation of nuclear release authority did not end with generals and air marshals. In his work for the Pentagon in 1961, Daniel Ellsberg discovered that such authority cascaded down the military hierarchy through sub-delegation. It soon became clear to him that relatively junior commanders believed it was for them to decide whether to push the button. During his visits to regional commands, Ellsberg discovered various accidents waiting to happen, including with commanders who brazenly asserted their willingness to use nuclear weapons if, in their judgement, that was necessary. The system of positive control (or Fail-Safe) referred to earlier, required bombers to turn round if they did not receive the go-code (or ‘Execute’ order). When Ellsberg interviewed a base commander in the US Pacific Command, he asked what would happen if his aircraft were scrambled and headed for their Fail-Safe points and did not receive the ‘Execute’ order. His reply was: ‘If they didn’t get any Execute message? Oh, I think they’d come back.’ He paused. ‘Most of them.’[22] When Daniel Ellsberg went to see *Dr Strangelove* with a fellow RAND colleague in the Pentagon, they emerged from the cinema in agreement that what they had just watched was ‘essentially a documentary.’[23]

The more fascinating revelations about nuclear delegation in October 1962 have been from the Soviet side. This is especially intriguing, given that in the USSR, Soviet marshals were forbidden from taking the initiative. The Soviet political leadership were adamant on the supremacy of the Communist Party in any decision to fight a nuclear war. The result was a highly centralised system of command and control, designed to remove the possibility that the military could start a nuclear war. Yet, although this applied to strategic nuclear weapons, the situation was different in the Caribbean. While the secrets of nuclear command and control have been amongst the most closely guarded of the Cold War (and beyond), revelations about Soviet deployments in the Caribbean have given rise to speculation and debate about risks that junior Soviet commanders might have marched their cohorts across the Rubicon.